

HANDOUT
PUT YOUR RESEARCH IN WRITING:
Tips on Writing a Genealogy Case Study

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Definition of a Case Study

- A genealogical question or problem that is resolved through targeted research
- Shorter than a book – more article length in size
- Could be made into an article, incorporated into a book, or kept in your own files
- Great way to work on a genealogy brick wall with more “bite-sized” information

Genealogical Proof Standard

- 1. Reasonably exhaustive research necessary to address the question
- 2. Each statement of fact has a complete and accurate source citation
- 3. All evidence has been thoroughly and skillfully interpreted and correlated
- 4. Any conflicts in evidence have been resolved
- 5. Write a soundly reasoned, coherently written conclusion based on all the evidence
- Our talk today is about doing Point 5, using the other 4 points

Writing Elements: The Introduction

- Grab reader’s attention
- Set case study into focus
- Establish context for the problem
- Describes the problem succinctly
- Reveals solution to the problem

CASE STUDY



Introduction

The Problem to be resolved is stated. Opening thesis.

A summary is made of opening evidence: what was available about the problem initially before more targeted research

Bottom of the page: documentation in the form of footnotes. Each statement of fact is documented.

Planning the Case Study:

- Formulate questions that need answers
- What sources exist that might answer these questions
- Explore geography of the place using maps and other guides
- Explore digital and archival resources for locality and related locality
- Research the state/colonial laws in place for land, inheritance, and court (since records may be located elsewhere in a different venue than the county)

Conducting “reasonably exhaustive research” necessary to address question

- Create a research plan
- Make a methodical search through available records – original sources
- Report any negative findings (the sources you checked that did not have the answer)
- Create timelines for the person or family being studied

Skillfully interpreting and correlating evidence

- Look closely for linkages to your question
- FAN Principle (family, friends, neighbors of your ancestor)
- Study the evidence at hand closely: direct versus indirect evidence
- Accumulate evidence from different sources (probate, land, court)
- Eliminate possibilities and narrowing your focus
- Summarize your findings in what you write
- We may create a more-lengthy written report for our own use, but if we are writing a book or article, we may only need to summarize our findings (with appropriate footnotes to what we examined)
- We report negative evidence – sources that we searched where we found nothing

CASE STUDY



Correlation and Interpretation: Developing a Proof Argument

Describe and Summarize findings

Use sub-headers to divide our case study into smaller bites

Show why we accepted some evidence and rejected other families of the same name

Explain logic and reasoning – linear and logical in focus

Resolve conflicts in the evidence

Writing should support thesis or question in opening paragraph

Full documentation in footnotes

White Queen Test (Robert Charles Anderson, *Elements of Genealogical Analysis* [2014])

- Derives from White Queen from Lewis Carroll's *Alice through the Looking Glass*, who believed six impossible things before breakfast
- Turn your analysis upside down – what would you have to believe if your theory is not true

CASE STUDY



Writing a soundly reasoned conclusion

- Short, only a couple of paragraphs
- Restating of the problem and how it was resolved
- Points out unusual findings
- Historical context can be applied if applicable
- Sound closing sentence

Some Tips on Writing Well

- Use active verbs where possible
- Make sure statements are supported by the evidence cited
- Use topical sentences to begin each paragraph
- Qualify statements appropriately to the degree of uncertainty
- Simplify. Try to convey point in fewest necessary words
- Read articles in journals of record or Jacobus Award-winning genealogies

Selected Bibliography

Anderson, Robert Charles. *Elements of Genealogical Analysis*. (2014).

Board for Certification of Genealogists. *Genealogy Standards*. 2nd ed, (2019).

Jones, Thomas P. *Mastering Genealogical Proof*. (2013).

Mills, Elizabeth Shown. *Evidence Explained: Citing History Sources from Artifacts to Cyberspace*. 3rd edition revised. 2017.